University of Florida
College of Public Health & Health Professions Syllabus
PHC 6521: Fundamentals of Public Health Nutrition
Credit Hours: 3
Fall 2025
Delivery Format: E-Learning in Canvas

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Preferred Course Communications: Direct email (Hastark@ufl.edu) through Outlook email. Please **include PHC6521 in the subject line**. This is the preferred method of communication, not the message function within Canvas. Emails received on weekdays (Monday-Thursday) can expect a response within 24 to 48 hours. Don't hesitate to contact me again if I have not responded within two days. Your message is important to me, but it may have been overlooked. Emails received during the weekend or after 5 pm on Friday will be answered the following Monday.

Prerequisites: None

PURPOSE AND OUTCOME

Public health nutrition involves the promotion of health through nutrition and the prevention of nutrition-related diseases in a population. It focuses on improving food choices, dietary intake, and nutritional status at the community, regional, national, and global levels. The public health nutrition professional works to assess nutritional problems and needs by considering social and environmental causes, identifying intervention points, developing policies and programs to intervene at those points, implementing the policies or programs, and evaluating the effectiveness of the intervention.

Course Overview

This course will provide an introduction to Public Health Nutrition and the role of the public health professional and nutrition. Emphasis will be on the definition, identification, and prevention of nutrition-related diseases, as well as improving the health of a population by improving nutrition. Malnutrition will be discussed on a societal, economic, and environmental level. It will include the basics of nutritional biochemistry as it relates to malnutrition of a community and targeted intervention. Finally, it will review existing programs and policies, including strengths, weaknesses, and areas for modification or new interventions.

Relation to Program Outcomes

MPH Competencies covered

1. Monitor health status to identify and solve community health problems
2. Assess population needs, assets and capacities that affect community health
3. Diagnose and investigate health problems and health hazards in the community using an ecological framework
4. Inform, educate, and empower people about health issues
5. Mobilize community partnerships and action to identify and solve health problems

6. Develop policies and plans that support individual and community health efforts
7. Evaluate the multifactorial etiology of health outcomes
8. Design a population-based program, project or intervention
9. Evaluate the effectiveness, accessibility, and quality of personal and population-based health services
10. Conduct research for new insights and innovative solutions to health problems

Course Objectives and/or Goals

1. Describe the theory and practice of public health nutrition.
2. Summarize the history and development of nutritional science, dietary intake guidance, and food/nutrition services and programs.
3. Compare the strengths and weaknesses of current government provided supplemental nutrition services and resources.
4. Evaluate methods for conducting community nutrition status assessments and identify gaps for current nutrition needs of communities.
5. Characterize populations at the greatest risk for malnutrition and nutrition related disease and factors that contribute to these issues such as biologic, cultural, socioeconomic, and nutritional determinants of diet-related disease risks.
6. Explain nutritional epidemiology and understand its role in health and disease.
7. Distinguish the major study designs in nutritional epidemiology.
8. Align methodologies for nutrition intervention from an individual, community, program and policy level in a community-based setting.
9. Evaluate educational resources and public nutrition services available, identifying which programs target food insecurity, hunger, nutritional deficiencies, over nutrition and diet-related chronic disease.
10. Design a community-based audience specific nutrition education program and educational messaging that are appropriate for a defined community.

Instructional Methods

1. Lectures are for general orientation and the delivery of course content. Students are responsible for all the material presented in the course and assigned readings.
2. Readings and Resources: In addition to the required texts, supplementary readings and resources will be posted in the course. The reading list may be supplemented during the course.
3. Assessments: A variety of assessments will be used in this course, including but not limited to quizzes, special projects, and journal club discussions.

What is expected of you?

You are expected to actively engage in the course throughout the semester. You are expected to watch the lectures and videos and complete the assigned readings. This preparation gives you the knowledge and practice needed to engage in higher levels of learning required for the assignments and discussions. Your participation fosters a rich course experience for you and your peers that facilitates overall mastery of the course objectives.

DESCRIPTION OF COURSE CONTENT

Week	Date	Topic	Assignments Due Mondays
	Introduction to Public Health Nutrition		
1	Aug 18th	• Introduction to the course and Public Health Nutrition	• Sign up for Journal club • Peer Introduction
	Module 1: Nutritional Epidemiology, Policy, & Programs		
2	Aug 25th	• Nutrition Assistance Programs • Public Policy and Nutrition	• Sign up for Journal Club • Introduction Peer response • SNAP Lab
3	Sept 1st	• Food Security • Food Safety	• Food Security Lab • Food Safety Lab
4	Sept 8th	• Public Health Nutrition Epidemiology	• Journal Club 1 • Quiz Module 1 • (Track diet using an App next week)
	Module 2- Nutritional Assessments, Nutrition in Communities		
5	Sept 15th	• Dietary Assessment • Clinical Assessment	• Dietary Assessment Lab • Nutrition Program Evaluation
6	Sept 22nd	• Nutritional Needs in Communities • Community Needs Assessment • Theories of Behavior Change	• Quiz Module 2 • Journal Club 2 • Response to Dietary assessment lab
	Module 3- Individual and Population Nutrition		
7	Sept 29th	• Malnutrition • Undernutrition, Overnutrition • Sustainable Development Goals	• Community Needs Assessment • SDG lab
8	Oct 6th	• Micronutrients/ Macronutrients • Minerals • Supplementation	• Nutrition Lab • Submit Nutrition Program project topic • Journal Club 3
9	Oct 13th	• Nutrition Program Development • Individual vs. Community Intervention	• Quiz Module 3 • Nutrition Program target population, project geographic location.
	Module 4 -Nutrition through the Lifecycle		
10	Oct 20th	• Infant Young Child Nutrition & Feeding • Maternal Nutrition	• Nutrition Program Project goals and objectives, background significance • Journal Club 4

11	Oct 27th	• Nutrition in Adolescence • Nutrition in Adulthood and Aging • Elderly	• Quiz Module 4 • Lab: Public Health on Call • Nutrition Program Project Methodology
	Module 5 - Community Nutrition and Disease		
12	Nov 3rd	• Cardiovascular Disease • Diabetes	• Journal Club 5 • Nutrition and Disease Lab
13	Nov 10th	• Nutrition and Disease • Obesity • Eating Disorders	• Nutrition Program Proposal draft due
14	Nov 17th	• Global Nutrition	• Quiz Module 5 • Peer review Nutrition Program Proposal
15	Nov 24th	Thanksgiving Break	
16	Dec 1st	Nutrition Program Proposal Due	

Course Materials and Technology

Required Textbook:
There is no required textbook for this course. Reading material will be provided by the instructor through Canvas. Students must have a working webcam and microphone to participate in this course. Students

ACADEMIC REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING

Assignments
All assignments, unless otherwise specified, will be **due on Mondays by 11:59 pm.**

1. Peer Introduction
Please create a short video introducing yourself to the class. Share information about your background, your goals, and your interests. In addition, please say hello to at least 2 other classmates. You will interact virtually throughout the semester, and this is a good way to get to know your peers.

2. Labs (20% of course grade)
Purpose and relationship to course goals: The labs are an opportunity for students to engage in in-depth participation to practice, explore, and gain mastery of the material through the use of interdisciplinary tools and techniques.

Throughout the semester, you will complete labs for several modules to reinforce and build on the materials presented in the lectures. These labs are applied experiential approaches to learning. The purpose of the labs is to engage in in-depth participation to practice, explore, and gain mastery of the material through the use of disciplinary tools and techniques.

3. Quizzes (10% of course grade)
Purpose and relationship to course goals: The quizzes are an opportunity for students to demonstrate course content and knowledge, apply their knowledge to new situations, and reflect on the key themes through a variety of question styles and types.

There are 5 short online assessments designed to test whether you have the basic knowledge, definitions, and concepts related to the course's focal topics. These quizzes are intended to help reinforce the lecture and reading material in each module and help you judge your understanding of the course content prior to applying that content in class. Quizzes will be completed online through Canvas and focus on the module content, lecture recordings, and readings found in Canvas. Quiz question formats will be multiple choice, select multiple answers, fill-in, and short answer.

4. **Nutrition Projects (40% of course grade)**
Purpose and relationship to course goals: The assignments are designed to help students analyze situations, apply their knowledge, and practice communication-related to concepts in public health nutrition.

There are 3 nutrition projects for this course which are based on a nutrition-sensitive topic. The principles from each project will build upon the course material and be applied to your final nutrition program project. A brief outline of these projects is provided below. Additional information about each assignment can be found in the course site, including grading rubrics for each assignment.

I. **Nutrition Program Analysis (10% of grade)**
For this assignment, pick an existing, well-functioning nutrition program. This program should be established and can be at the local, state, national or global level. If your target program/ organization is large-scale, select a small portion of the overall program to focus on for your evaluation. For instance, you may pick WIC, but WIC is a huge program, so you should focus on one program in WIC, for instance, the Breastfeeding Program. Once you have identified your program, you will conduct an evaluation of the program.

II. **Community Needs Assessment: (10% of grade)**
For your final nutrition project, you will design a nutrition intervention in a community. For this assignment, determine what community you will target for your intervention. Within the community, identify a target population. Complete a needs assessment for your target community.

III. **Nutrition Program Project or Nutrition Research Study (20% of grade)**
In this third part, you will create a proposal for a nutrition project to develop a smaller-scale program or research study (based on your concentration and area of interest) that can target a smaller or more focused audience. For instance, using the breastfeeding example in part one, you may develop a breastfeeding support program for a targeted community. More details about this project can be found in the Assignment tool. As part of this assignment, you will conduct a peer review of a colleague's proposals.

5. Journal Club (25% of course grade)
Purpose and relationship to course goals: The objectives of the journal clubs are to improve critical thinking with research related to this course, to develop an approach to the analysis of various types of articles, to understand how study results can be used in Public Health practice, and to keep current with nutrition-related literature.

Journal clubs are a way for students to stay current with advances in public health. You are required to pick a selected peer-reviewed journal article relating to public health nutrition and present the article to your peers. There are 5 journal club weeks throughout the semester. For the weeks you are not presenting, you must attend one journal club and participate in the discussion using perusal.

We will have our 1st journal club during the 4th week of class.

I. Journal Club Presentation Description (15% of course grade)
You will present and facilitate one journal club article discussion during the semester. You will sign up to present a peer-reviewed article relating to one of the topics covered in this course. For your presentation, you will take the role of the facilitator. In this capacity, you will lead the class in a review

of the article by recording yourself presenting the article to your classmates. Your critique of the article will need to include: an overview of the background, goals and aims, methodology, use of Public Health Nutrition principles, strengths and weaknesses, implications for Public Health Nutrition, and directions for future research.

Present your article in a short video presentation that is **4-5 minutes**. Points will be deducted for presentations longer than 5 minutes. Presentations will be graded based on the rubric in the assignment.

As part of this assignment, you, the facilitator, will prepare **three thoughtful questions** based on the article and use these questions to lead the journal club discussion. The facilitator will lead the discussion by posting their questions at the end of their presentation. Students will answer at least one question. Facilitators are expected to moderate the discussion for the next week and reply appropriately to students' answers and comments.

Journal presentations should **be 4-5 minutes**, **no longer than 5 minutes** long and must **be posted the Sunday before we discuss them in the course**. Title your presentation critique by your name and the article you are reviewing.

II. Journal Club Discussion (10%)

For each Journal Club week, students who are **not presenting are required to participate in 1 journal club presentation**. You are expected to 1) read the assigned articles, 2) watch the facilitator's presentations, and 3) then reply to one of the three questions the facilitator posts during week 4) contribute **at least 4** thoughtful comments on the article, proposed questions, or peers' responses. The week you present, you do not have to participate in other journal club discussions.

Grading

Requirement	Due Date	Percentage of grade
Labs	varies	20%
Quizzes (5 Quizzes)	varies	10%
Journal Club Presentation	varies	15%
Journal Club Discussion (4 Journal Club participations)	varies	10%
Nutrition Program Evaluation		10%
Community Needs Assessment		10%
Nutrition Program Project		20%
Peer Review / Peer Introduction	varies	5%
Total Course		100%

Point system used

Scale	93.0 - 100%	90.0 – 92.9%	87.0 – 89.9%	83.0– 86.9%	80.0 – 82.9%	77 – 79.9%	73 -76.9%
Letter Grade	**A**	**A-**	**B+**	**B**	**B-**	**C+**	**C**

Grade Points	4.0	3.67	3.33	3.0	2.67	2.33	2.0

Please be aware that a C- is not an acceptable grade for graduate students. The GPA for graduate students must be 3.0 based on 5000 level courses and above to graduate. A grade of C counts toward a graduate degree only if based on credits in courses numbered 5000 or higher that have been earned with a B+ or higher.

More information on UF grading policy may be found at: https://catalog.ufl.edu/UGRD/academic-regulations/attendance-policies/

Policy Related to Make-up Exams or Other Work and late work
Please note: Any requests for make-ups due to technical issues MUST be accompanied by the UF Computing help desk (http://helpdesk.ufl.edu/) correspondence. You MUST e-mail me within 24 hours of the technical difficulty if you wish to request a make-up. Please note all faculty are bound by the UF policy for excused absences for coursework.

Unexcused late work will be docked 10% of the assignment grade per day.

Policy related to AI Use in this course
All submitted work must be original, and AI tools are not permitted for generating content. Critical thinking skills are part of the learning outcomes of this course, all assignments should be prepared by the student. Developing strong competencies in this area will prepare you for a competitive workplace.

STUDENT EXPECTATIONS, ROLES, AND OPPORTUNITIES FOR INPUT

Expectations Regarding Course Behavior
Please see the "Welcome-Start Here" section in the canvas home page. Students are expected to check the announcements regularly for important information and course updates. Please note that announcements and emails sent through canvas will go to your UFL email. No correspondences will be sent to outside emails. Students should reference the calendar in the course regularly to keep up with weekly assignments

Communication Guidelines
Please post questions related to the course materials directly on the course board entitled "seek clarification" so that all students may benefit from the answer provided.
For other matters, please email the instructor or the TA directly, see emails above.
Please refer to this link to the Netiquette Guidelines for expectations and appropriate guidelines on Netiquette:
http://teach.ufl.edu/wp-content/uploads/2012/08/NetiquetteGuideforOnlineCourses.pdf

Inclusive Learning Environment
Public health and health professions are based on the belief in human dignity and on respect for the individual. As we share our personal beliefs inside or outside of the classroom, it is always with the understanding that we value and respect diversity of background, experience, and opinion, where every individual feels valued. We believe in, and promote, openness and tolerance of differences in ethnicity and culture, and we respect differing personal, spiritual, religious and political values. We further believe that celebrating such diversity enriches the quality of the educational experiences we provide our students and enhances our own personal and professional relationships. We embrace The University of Florida's Non-Discrimination Policy, which reads, "The University shall actively promote equal opportunity policies and practices conforming to laws against discrimination. The University is committed to non-discrimination with respect to race, creed, color, religion, age, disability, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity and expression, marital status, national origin, political opinions or affiliations, genetic information and veteran status as protected under the Vietnam Era Veterans' Readjustment Assistance Act."